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# Shadows Under a Full Moon

**Ridham Janve**'s latest, *Hunter's Moon*, is a 'spiritual western' set in the Dhauladhars

Ridham Janve's *Kaatti Ri Raatti* (*Hunter's Moon*), which won him the 'Best Screenplay Award' at the Shanghai International Film Festival, was conceived not on a writing table but around a bonfire with friends from the Gaddi community, whose tales of encounters with the unknown had started resonating with him over the years spent living in the Dhauladhars.

Even as the director of the acclaimed *The Gold-Laden Sheep and the Sacred Mountain* describes *Hunter's Moon* as a "spiritual western", he warns, "While it borrows the genre's fixtures—a man with a gun, a hostile landscape—you won't find the Western's craving for conquest. What emerges is uncertainty: a conflict not between men, or even man and animal, but longing and consequence, belief and integrity."



That sensibility was moulded as much by the landscape as by purpose. The Himalayas taught him to acknowledge what can't always be explained—a sudden mist enveloping the world, a sound from somewhere unseen. After the birth of his son, Janve started spending time in Goa, from where he continued work on the film: "Goa introduced a different rhythm: mountains tutor stillness, the sea speaks of motion and return. Nature is not merely a backdrop but a force driving my films."

As in *The Gold-Laden Sheep*, he has cast non-actors from the Gaddi community. "Their bodies belong to that world and carry a truth no trained performer can bring forth," insists Janve.

The edit, undertaken at a distance with Amit Dutta, unfolded like a correspondence chess match: footage was sent in narrative order, with Dutta refusing to look ahead. "Out of that exchange emerged the film's voiceovers—and a movie that revealed itself to both of us slowly." ■

***—Sukant Deepak***

> The film has the western's fixtures—**MAN WITH A GUN, HOSTILE LAND**—but not its craving for conquest



**UNKNOWN DARK** The film is inspired by the Gaddi community's encounters with the mysterious in the Himalayas

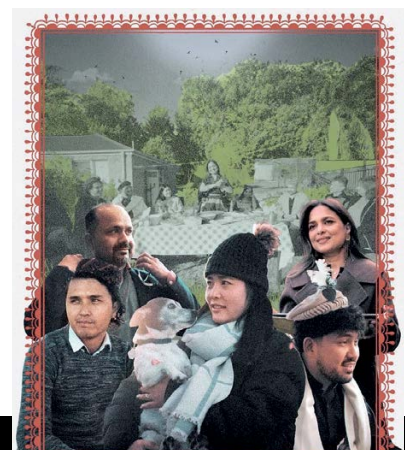
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# MORE THAN A MEAL

INDO-AUSTRALIAN FILMMAKER NANDITA CHAKRABORTY'S *SHARED TABLE: REGIONAL HEROES* IS A CELEBRATION OF THE CONNECTIONS FORMED AROUND A DINING TABLE

Nandita Chakraborty's documentary *Shared Table: Regional Heroes*, which had its world premiere at the 19th Mumbai International Film Festival (MIFF), follows a group of filmmakers as they journey through Victoria, Australia, interviewing "heroes" of the migrant communities. Through food, memory and conversation, the film explores how migrants preserve their cultural roots while building new lives far from home.

"Food is one of the most powerful expressions of identity. Long after people leave their homeland, they continue to carry recipes, traditions and memories with them. Around a dining table, stories unfold in ways they often don't during a formal interview," says Nandita. "As a migrant myself, I understand that food is much more than nourishment. It is comfort, memory, family and belonging. I wanted to use the shared table as a universal language that connects people."



Born in Kolkata and now based in Melbourne, Chakraborty has built a career telling stories of migration, belonging and resilience. Her life took an unexpected turn in 2011 when a rock-climbing accident left her with a traumatic brain injury and permanent cognitive disability. During her long rehabilitation, writing became a form of healing, eventually opening the door to filmmaking.

Drawn to stories that create empathy and inspire meaningful conversations, she wants to continue telling stories that give voice to people whose experiences are often overlooked. "For me, filmmaking has never been just about entertainment. It is about building understanding between communities," she concludes. ■

***—Deepa Natarajan Lobo***